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Party Responsiveness on European Union Integration in Transition Democracies of Central and Eastern Europe*

LUCIE SPANIHELOVA[1] and BRANDON C. ZICHA[2]
[1] Leiden University and Montesquieu Institute. [2] Leiden University College

Abstract

Some argue that the direct representative relationship between voters and party elites is difficult to establish in transition democracies. In part, the difficulty stems from the fact that parties may have a hard time discerning the preferences of their respective voter coalitions. In the case of EU integration, parties may have additional incentives to disregard the interests of the public in the hope of securing benefits associated with their country's membership of the EU. In this article we investigate the extent of party responsiveness on EU integration issues in early transition years in central and eastern European countries. We find that while mainstream parties do consistently show more support for EU integration, we find no evidence that parties, in fact, track their voters. The lack of responsiveness cannot, however, be explained by the general instability of public and party positions, nor can this absence of a relationship be satisfactorily captured by low salience of the EU in the transition years.

Introduction

In recent years, party representation of European Union integration issues has received heightened scholarly attention. The growing public discontent with a 'democratic deficit' in the EU brings the discussion back to the primary movers of the integration process: political elites and their parties. While the lion's share of attention has been devoted to the behaviour of parties in western European democratic systems, only a few comparative studies have emerged so far focusing on the conditions of such party behaviour in central and eastern European (CEE) countries (Taggart and Szczerbiak, 2004; Marks *et al*., 2006; Rohrschneider and Whitefield, 2007; Whitefield and Rohrschneider, 2009; Vachudova, 2005, 2008).

However, continuing attention and examination of the logic behind party positions in CEE on issues associated with integration into supranational institutions, such as the EU, offers a unique insight into the manner in which international organizations and domestic political structures interact in new democracies. The membership benefits that supranational institutions offer affect the behaviour of domestic political elites such that they may trump their representative concerns. Previous research argues that democratic transitions are plagued by the uncertainty of domestic political actors that they will be able to successfully carry out and sustain political and economic reforms (Mansfield and Pevehouse, 2006). External actors – such as the EU – provide a venue through which domestic political elites are able to credibly commit to such reforms (Pevehouse, 2002;

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Mansfield and Pevehouse, 2006). Thus, joining international organizations and tying the hands of the political leadership by integrating into the global international structures predominantly composed of other democratic member states sends a strong signal to their respective constituencies regarding their commitment to liberalization and democratization. It is precisely for this reason EU integration issues should play a non-trivial role in parties' strategies in the early transition democracies; even more so than in established democracies in western Europe.

This article examines party responsiveness with regards to EU integration issues in the early years of CEE countries' transitional period where EU membership incentives strongly shaped national elites' strategic choices. We examine parties' willingness to adjust their position on EU integration in response to public preferences, building on three competing explanations. First, the elite collusion hypothesis suggests that as the anticipated benefits of membership in the EU play an increasingly crucial role for national elites in transitioning democracies, EU integration becomes an elite-driven project removed from the public eye. Thus all parties with a high probability of attaining positions in government will be equally vested in steering the country towards EU membership regardless of public preference on the issue of EU integration. Second, and alternatively, we also propose that parties' positions on EU integration are, in fact, a result of a representative connection between voters and party elites. In this sense, representative concerns will trump party elites' membership benefits expectations and thus parties will choose to be ultimately responsive to shifts in public preferences on EU integration. We test these two competing arguments in a unified model. Finally, we also account for the specifics of the emerging democracies and suggest a third argument whereby the lack of responsiveness of parties to their constituency preferences is simply a characteristic of system-wide non-responsiveness resulting from the electoral volatility of new party systems.

This study contributes to the scholarly discussion of the elite–voter connection on EU integration and explicitly explores the generalizability of the current explanations in the setting of transitional democracies during their run-up to EU membership. Further, examining the behaviour of political parties in the pre-accession period provides a unique opportunity where general arguments regarding the impact of supranational or international institutions on the incentives of national party elites can be directly addressed. In contrast to previous similar tests in this geographical region, we utilize party manifesto data that provide a more dynamic measure of party positions than commonly used expert scores.

This article is organized as follows. First, we discuss the three competing explanations of party positions on EU integration, drawing carefully on the existing studies in western and eastern Europe. Second, we describe our research design and discuss our findings. We show that elite collusion has a discernible role in political parties' stated views of EU integration in the period 1990–97. However, we find no evidence that representational concerns made an observable impact on parties' positions on EU integration. Additionally, we show that there exist substantially divergent levels of responsiveness across two issues: EU membership and free-market positions. This evidence substantively falsifies the claim that general electoral volatility makes responsiveness unlikely in these new democracies during this time period. Finally, we also demonstrate that such behaviour is not an artefact of the low salience of the EU in party manifestos whereby parties deliberately de-emphasize EU integration so that their effort to navigate the country toward EU membership is not hindered by excessive public attention. We conclude with suggestions

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for future research and the significance of this study in the wider context of party responsiveness on the EU and the role of supranational actors in party representation.

I. Party Responsiveness on EU Integration in CEE: Three Hypotheses

EU integration has conventionally played a marginal role in party competition in western Europe, holding only limited influence over voters' electoral choices. New research focusing on the more recent developments in CEE countries suggests that parties and voters share a similar view of the EU's secondary importance to other domestic concerns as in the case of their western European counterparts (Lewis and Enyedi, 2006, p. 243; Haughton, 2009). Researching the tumultuous transition years in CEE countries, however, requires addressing a number of specifics that will be investigated in this article. Exploring these context-specific possibilities is particularly important if we are to compare the way EU issues are represented in CEE countries with the theoretical arguments made in the case of western European political systems.

On the one hand, it is quite plausible that EU integration played a more prominent role in domestic political discourse in transition democracies and therefore may have uniquely shaped the representative dynamics in CEE democracies – most particularly with regard to issues of EU integration. Research on the external sources of democratization suggests that international integration enables national elites to link difficult political reforms to their membership in these structures. Furthermore, the symbolic value of integrating within the western European supranational structures was often invoked by prominent political elites in early years of democratic transition in the CEE as one of the most pressing goals of the transition period.[1]

On the other hand, the dynamics of the exchange between voters and political elites during the transition period is also marked by specific problems endemic to newly emerging democratic systems. Many studies have suggested a significant disconnect between voters and parties as new parties emerge which, however, are relatively short-lived, thus decreasing incentives for political accountability (Whitefield, 2002, p. 183). One of the most intriguing consequences of political systems in flux is that voters may be reluctant to take cues from such emerging parties (Tucker *et al*., 2002), thus potentially minimizing the feedback effect of political manoeuvring and agenda-setting that represents such a prominent feature of western European political systems. The pronounced benefits of the EU membership, along with the limited ability of voters to hold parties accountable, put representation on EU issues at substantial risk.

Drawing on the existing studies of political parties with respect to EU integration we examine three competing arguments that explain the link between voters and party positions. This research on the relationship between voters and party elites regarding EU integration issues has yet to provide a definitive answer as to whether or not representation is occurring. This article extends the empirical scope of these studies by devoting attention to CEE countries and helps to fill the current deficit in studies of the nature of the EU issue in CEE.

[1] We thank an anonymous reviewer for drawing our attention to this point.

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The Elite Collusion Hypothesis

The collusion hypothesis builds on a set of arguments that views party behaviour with regards to EU issues as largely unrepresentative of the preferences of their constituents. It has become conventional wisdom that the majority of EU political elites in western Europe favour the European Union (Franklin and McGillivray, 1999). In a pioneering article Taggart (1998) notes that mainstream parties adopt a pro-EU position, while parties occupying the extreme ends of the political spectrum tend to fill in this void by taking a more consistent anti-EU stance. Ray (1999) provides a nuanced empirical exploration of the concept of 'mainstream' party by using a number of ideological and voter-centred measures of party strength. His findings confirm the consensus in the literature that 'mainstream' parties became increasingly pro-EU in the period from 1984 to 1996.

Others have pointed out that the salience of the EU dimension in domestic political competition must be addressed and that it provides a compelling explanation of party EU support. If, in fact, parties compete on different dimensions and navigate voters away from EU issues, then parties are free to choose their positions regardless of what the voters demand as long as they are able to satisfy their demands on other issues. Ray (2003a) provides evidence that cues from western European political parties on the EU dimension largely help to shape voters' preferences rather than voters' preferences driving partisan positions. Furthermore, his findings strongly support the elite-consensus hypothesis in that 'elites may act to discourage policy voting rather to reduce persuasiveness' (Ray, 2003a, p. 990). In the case of western EU Member States, Mair (2007, p. 12) similarly argues that 'political leaders dealing with Europe choose to contest elections on issues in which those elections cannot prove decisive, and to exclude those issues on which elections can prove decisive'.

In sum, research concentrating on western European Member States has argued from an elite-driven perspective that political parties, and mainstream parties in particular, are simply more pro-EU and that correspondence on this position cross-nationally is increasing. Ray (1999) argues using aggregate data on the positions of government parties and opposition parties that the distance between these groups of parties has become smaller over the years – at least with regards to the issue of the EU – suggesting that the distance between the political centre and the periphery is shrinking. This is a central element of the argument that political parties are less competitive on the issue of EU integration.

It is plausible that the anticipated benefits of EU membership expected by CEE countries after accession provides equally strong, if not stronger, incentive to adopt consistently pro-EU positions. Furthermore, as noted before, political representatives in transition democracies are in a vulnerable position and can rely on membership in the EU to assign credibility to reforms they are asked to carry out during this period (Mansfield and Pevehouse, 2006). As some have aptly observed, 'the EU was seen as a model of prosperity, a model for reforms the candidates were prepared to emulate [. . .] [E]mulation also has the potential to explain the high level of compliance among CEE states with the EU's demands for democratic change, especially in the early, less targeted period' (Dimitrova and Pridham, 2004, p. 105).

The effect of EU membership prospects on party positions has been suggested in a couple of studies (Taggart and Szczerbiak, 2004, 2008). Thus, the underlying process guiding the position of political parties on EU issues is argued to be firmly rooted in the

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individual career ambitions of party members. EU membership opens up a venue for career and policy opportunities for politicians to pursue. Supranational political opportunities become increasingly accessible if partisan elites are known for their pro-EU policies in the case where a country is pursuing EU accession. Furthermore, it is not uncommon that many high-ranking national political elites (particularly those with favourable EU policy views) continue their political careers in the European Commission. One prominent example is Vladimír Špidla, who negotiated much of the final terms of accession for the Czech Republic, and then promptly joined the European Commission as his domestic political prospects became more uncertain (Pečinka, 2004).

Alternatively, positions in the Council of Ministers or European Commission may be sought to boost the politician's profile and enhance his or her capacity to attain national-level office, as in the case of Romano Prodi in Italy (Stolz, 2002). Scholars have adequate reason to believe that the EU provides political benefits to those able to attain them. Thus, from the elite collusion hypothesis we derive the following expectations:

H1: Mainstream political parties will be more pro-EU than less mainstream parties.

H1a: Political parties will become more anti-EU the further away they are from the centre of political competition.

H1b: Political parties with high vote shares will be more pro-EU than those with lower vote shares.

The Voter–Elite Connection Hypothesis

The primary alternative to the arguments undergirding the elite collusion hypothesis are the foundational arguments of party representation: if parties are motivated by re-election, they should adjust their positions in keeping with the views of their constituents rather than bear the costs of defection by voters dissatisfied with their party's lack of responsiveness over salient issues. In other words, in representative democracies changes in preferences of the public should be reflected by changes in the positions of political parties.

Carrubba (2001) presents evidence that positions of political parties on the EU among western European Member States more or less track their respective constituencies in the period 1972–92. The argument is that public disinterest in EU affairs often suggested in relation to the so-called 'permissive consensus' (Key, 1961, pp. 32–5; Hooghe and Marks, 2008) is, in fact, an indication that parties dutifully represent the preferences of their constituents. Carrubba's study is one of the few explicit examinations of the link between party positions and voter preferences on the EU to date.

Some studies of the positions of parties on EU integration issues in CEE countries provide ample reason to suspect that parties in CEE will possess similar incentives to adjust their positions in accordance with shifts in their constituency preferences. For example, the common contention is that while mainstream western European political parties do not sufficiently differentiate themselves on EU issues, parties in CEE countries provide a more complex picture – one where parties manage to provide more distinct policy alternatives on EU issues (Rohrschneider and Whitefield, 2007). Scholars conclude that while parties seem to be more in favour of EU integration, the variance in the positions of political parties in CEE is substantially larger and the opposition to the EU is

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not merely relegated to fringe parties as we observe in western Europe (Taggart and Szczerbiak, 2004, 2008; Marks *et al*., 2006; Rohrschneider and Whitefield, 2007).

In this sense, if parties do indeed differentiate themselves from each other on EU integration more than in the CEE countries, then we should see more representation on EU integration. Rohrschneider and Whitefield (2007) demonstrate that in the early 2000s political parties perform remarkably well in representing their respective constituencies. Using expert surveys conducted in 2003, they assess the positions of the parties on three fronts – their position on western integration generally, deeper political integration of the EU, and deeper integration of the common market – and show that the parties tend to follow their respective constituencies in all three survey categories.

Thus, it is plausible that levels of varying political competition are important explanatory variables of parties' position taking on the EU dimension in CEE. Implicitly, the virtues of competitive political systems lie in their ability to increase information exchange between the citizens and the political actors, making them less prone to rent-seeking and more prone to act towards the general welfare of their respective constituencies to avoid being detected and punished come election time. This argument implies that the existence of a competitive political system promotes the linear and smooth translation of constituency preferences into the positions of the political parties. Thus we derive the following testable hypothesis.

> *H2*: *Ceteribus paribus*, as the pro-EU position of party identifiers increases, parties will increase their favourable position on EU integration issues.

Electoral Volatility Hypothesis

The two previous hypotheses implicitly assume that any relationship between parties and voters with respect to EU membership issues can be also applied directly to the transition democracies in CEE. However, much of the examination of the exchange between voters and parties in political systems of the CEE region has been explicitly and implicitly guided by a 'null hypothesis' (Tucker, 2002, p. 292) whereby the political exchange in transition countries is marked by a lack of discernible pattern (Tucker, 2002; Innes, 2002). This lack of identifiable electoral pattern is primarily attributed to the absence of stable political cleavages creating an absence of stable voter identification and thus implying a heightened expectation of programmatic volatility and diminished incentives for accountability and responsiveness among the political parties during the early transition period (Whitefield, 2002; Tucker, 2002).

This argument provides a critical alternative to any explanation of representative non-responsiveness on any particular issue or issues in transition countries in the CEE region. The logic of it implies a system-wide non-responsiveness of parties to voters, including their non-responsiveness on EU membership issues. Thus, observed non-responsiveness is not a result of a deliberate collusion among political parties as was suggested in the case of western Europe on a specific issue, but rather a spontaneous reaction to the electoral incentives generated in the political system at that time. Thus, care must be taken to ensure that representation in the CEE region *does* exist on some issues but does not on others, *and* that non-responsiveness on a particular issue conforms to a unique theoretically implied pattern.

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If parties do not track their voters on EU integration as a result of the excessive electoral volatility of political systems in transition, a missing link between parties and voters should be shared across issues and therefore warrants additional comparison with those issues. However, it is not essential to examine all issues that parties contest on during their electoral campaign to articulate a workable hypothesis. In this sense, if we find evidence that parties do, in fact, consistently track voters on another issue, the electoral volatility argument should be sufficiently falsified as it would represent an instance in which party elites were willing to follow their respective electoral coalitions on some issues, while not on others.

Thus, we examine the correspondence between voters and parties on the free market issue to investigate the propositions of the electoral volatility argument. Much like in the case of EU membership, the free-market positions of voters have been linked to the same underlying cleavage of 'winners' and 'losers' of democratic transition (Tucker *et al.*, 2002). In this sense, voters who are supportive of EU membership are also likely to hold positive views of economic liberalism, and trade liberalization more specifically. Thus parties should be expected to display similar levels of responsiveness on both issues as voters display consistency in how they link the issue of economic liberalism with EU integration issues and as they tap into the similar underlying political cleavages. Thus, we formulate the following hypothesis:

> *H3a*: As the pro-market position of party identifiers increases, parties will increase their pro-market position as well.

The electoral volatility argument presented in this section, has, however, yet another logical implication that deserves empirical scrutiny and may, paradoxically, imply the possibility of a much more extensive elite collusion than we discussed in the case of the original 'elite collusion hypothesis'. The electoral volatility of the early stages of the transition process also implies shifting institutions where the distribution of benefits through participation in government is still unclear and more difficult to predict (Shvetsova, 2003). As many medium- and small-sized parties garnered hopes of securing a place in future government coalitions, the incentives to adopt a pro-EU position was not merely relegated to mainstream parties. The uncertainty surrounding the access to government among the political parties and the legitimacy provided by the association with reforms recommended and later required by the EU institutions may transform EU membership issues into across-the-board favourable positions towards the EU among all political parties. Thus, we propose another plausible expectation in the case specific to the CEE countries.

> *H3b*: More ideologically extreme parties will adopt equal or more pro-EU positions than mainstream parties.

II. Research Design: Data, Measurement and Methods

Unlike the majority of the studies of party representation in the EU, we use party manifesto scores to measure the position of CEE political parties on EU integration. The choice is justified by two rationales. First, as our goal was to examine the early transition years in CEE countries, we were automatically relegated to rely on manifesto scores exclusively as no other measures of party positions that we are aware of provide early enough and consistent samples of positions in CEE. Second, as most of the findings so far

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rely on the same type of measurement – that is, expert evaluations of party positions – we consider our test in part a validity check for the results obtained in other research.

The main dependent variable is collected from parties' CMPII EU scores (Klingemann *et al*., 2007) for EU integration. To calculate this score, the Comparative Manifesto Project (CMP) data count the number of positive and negative statements in parties' manifestos on a whole array of policy issues as a potential of the total number of policy statements made in the manifesto. In the case of the EU position, the final score is calculated by subtracting the percentage of negative statements about EU integration out of all statements in the manifesto from the percentage of positive statements about EU integration out of all the statements in the manifesto. Thus:

$$EU\ score = \left(\frac{Positive\ Statements\ about\ EU}{Total\ Statements\ in\ Manifesto}\right) - \left(\frac{Negative\ Statements\ about\ EU}{Total\ Statements\ in\ Manifesto}\right) * 100 \quad (1)$$

Therefore, negative values on the final party score signify anti-EU position, zero means that negative and positive statements are in balance and positive values imply parties' pro-EU positions. The maximum possible value is 100 if all policy statements in the manifesto were pro-EU and –100 if all policy statements were negative. Not surprisingly, no party chose to identify themselves solely on EU issues.

Two main independent variables are used to examine our claims that the EU position of a party is driven by its voters' opinions of the EU, and that a party's position in CEE is driven by leaders' anticipation of future gains associated with membership in the EU. First, to account for the electoral connection between the elites and the voters we include a measure of the proportion of a party's electorate that identifies itself as pro-EU. More precisely, we calculate the percentage of a party's identifiers/voters that are pro-EU integration for each party in each individual election year. These data are collected from the Central and Eastern Eurobarometer (CEEB)[2] survey series that was conducted annually in post-communist countries from 1990 to 1997 (Commission, 1997). The survey includes the following question on EU membership: 'If (COUNTRY) were to join the European Community in the future, would you feel [. . .] strongly opposed, somewhat opposed, strongly in favour, somewhat in favour, or don't know?' Furthermore, the CEEB also asks the respondents to identify what party they are more likely to vote for in a future election. To compile the percentage of pro-EU voters for each party we have calculated the percentage of respondents that characterized themselves as strongly and somewhat pro-EU.

Second, in order to test the extent that parties in CEE collude by adopting positions favourable to the EU we measure a party's *legislative seat share* to account for the effect of the 'mainstreamness' of political parties on their position on the EU (Ray, 1999, 2003b). For the collusion hypothesis to hold, the higher seat share a party has, the more likely it is to emphasize pro-EU statements in their manifestos. Larger parties, regardless of their position on the left or right, are assumed to have higher expectations to reap policy and non-policy benefits of EU membership as they have higher chances of a government position in the future. We also include the party's *absolute ideological distance from the left–right median parliamentary party* in order to approximate the effect of the position of parties at the extreme ends of the ideological spectrum and hypothesize that left–right

[2] The Central and Eastern Eurobarometer (CEEB) Survey Series, available at: «http://zacat.gesis.org/webview/index.jsp».

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fringe parties are less likely to adopt pro-EU positions as well as that their chances to receive benefits from the EU are smaller as their chances to attain government position are lower. The use of the left–right dimension as the primary metric upon which to define a party's 'fringeness' follows the tradition of research on the identification of fringe versus mainstream parties. Indeed, most 'extreme' or fringe parties in CEE, as in western Europe, are usually identified by their 'extreme' position on the traditional left–right dimension. Further, we must presume, if our analysis about the connection between mainstream versus fringe parties and EU position is to have any merit, that 'mainstreamness' is a status that is at least possibly associated with any position on the EU issue.

However, we also suggested that the longer experience of party competition in regular elections in western democratic systems will make it is easier for political incumbents to anticipate the likelihood of being able to receive those benefits offered by supranational actors, such as the EU. Thus, the history of electoral successes and the number of terms spent in government conveys more information for party members in these systems to conduct crucial cost–benefit calculation and choose a position on EU issue. In transitioning political systems in their early years, on the other hand, as patterns of competition – and even the parties participating – are less fully stabilized and the anticipation of rewards associated with positions in government less predictable than in established democracies, we suggest that it is also plausible for the majority of parties to share similar expectations of the benefits of EU membership. Since most countries in our sample only experienced a few elections since their transition from communism, we find this alternative hypothesis quite plausible. Thus, if there is no discernible difference between mainstream and fringe parties, we should observe that the effect of the seat share and the distance on parties' pro-EU position will be zero or positive in the case of early transitioning countries in CEE.

Third, we include a trend variable by including year count to account for countries' increasing integration with the EU and thus the increase in possible gains to be made from emphasizing pro-EU positions. We created our year count variable by assigning a conventional year variable a unique ID that denoted the sequence of years. This procedure does not alter the substantive impact of a trend variable, but provides more substantively meaningful values of the constant in our models. We expect that this measure will be positively related to the position of parties such that as countries move closer to the EU and accession looms more closely, all parties' positions will become more pro-EU.

Next, we evaluate the robustness of these results by examining a number of possible objections to aspects of our analysis that may be an artefact of our data. Previous arguments have suggested that the EU position is largely a function of a more dominant left–right dimension that emphasizes socio-economic issues. Voters may not associate their views about the EU as strongly connected to the left–right and these left–right issues may simply dominate the attention of voters when considering which party to support. In the context of examining the behaviour of parties with respect to issues of the EU, Tsebelis and Garrett (2000), for example, argue and empirically demonstrate that particular components of the EU issue dimension are incorporated into the left–right dimension and thus do not constitute a separate dimension of political competition. Tucker *et al*. (2002) similarly show that EU support in post-communist countries matches the left–right cleavage. Specifically, they show that citizens' position on EU membership correlates strongly with their free-market positions, thus delineating a crucial political identity of the

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'winners' and 'losers' of transition. Thus we include a model specification where the CMP score of parties on the left–right dimension is derived from the CMPII data set in order to examine whether the EU position is just an artefact of parties tying their EU positions to the left–right dimension. After all, voters may arguably not conceive of the EU in such terms, and thus the lack of relationship between voters' views and party positions may be due to ignorance among voters on the left–right–EU linkage.

To measure public preferences on the free market, we again utilized the Eurobarometer survey trend file. The respondents were asked: 'Do you personally feel that the creation of a free-market economy, that is one largely free from state control, is right or wrong for (OUR COUNTRY'S) future?' We calculated the percentage of respondents that were supportive of the free market for each party in our sample. Furthermore, we derived our measure of party position on the free market from CMP data as well that includes favourable mentions of the free market (per401 + per414).

All of our analyses also control for temporal and cross-sectional correlations and include country fixed effects as well as lagged dependent variable. Both of these controls have also significant substantive effect. Controlling for the previous level of party support for the EU effectively creates a change dependent variable that directly addresses the dynamic changes in party responses to their respective voter coalitions. Further, inclusion of country fixed effects serves as a crucial control of systematic differences in country intercepts that can be attributed to a distinct *ex ante* level of political competitiveness in some countries. This particular point will be further discussed in the next section.

III. Findings

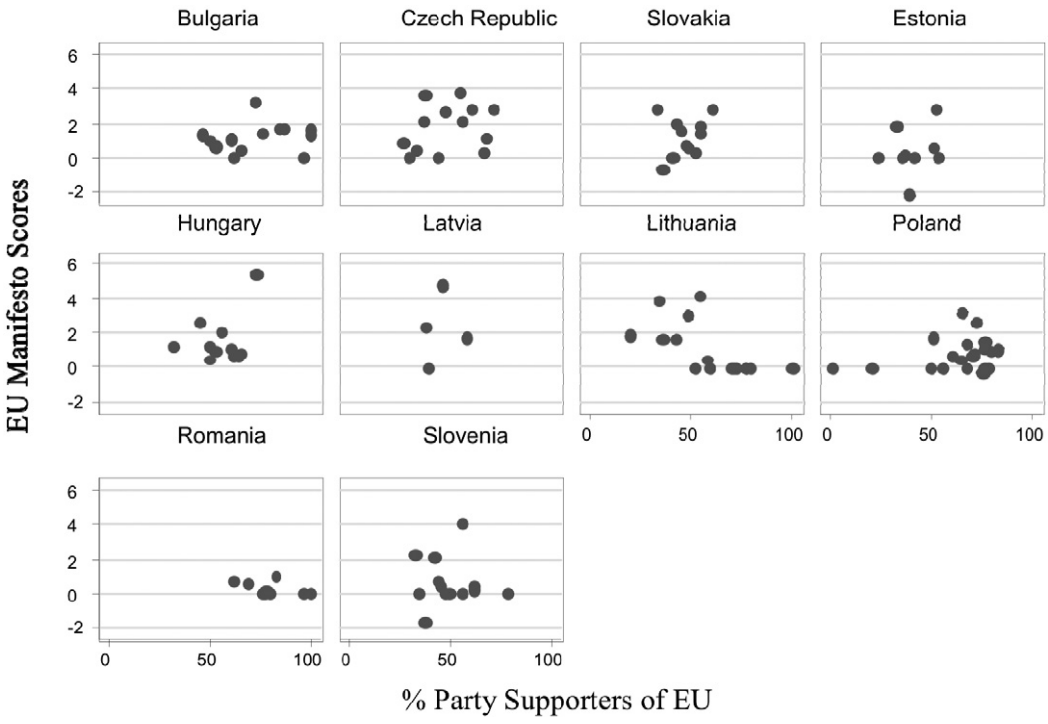
In order to arbitrate between the two general arguments explaining the EU position of parties in CEE early in transition, we isolate the effect of voters' preferences on party positions and contrast it with the influence of the degree of competitive differentiation of the mainstream parties on this issue. If, in fact, no viable opposition existed on the EU issue and instead the majority of the main parties adopted cohesive pro-EU positions, then the elite collusion argument is strengthened. Alternatively, if parties track the preferences of their voter coalitions, then our elite–voter connection hypothesis provides a better explanation for the behaviour of political parties in the early transition years in CEE countries.

An initial look at these data reveals a number of interesting patterns. Figure 1 shows that support for the EU in the public only very rarely falls below 30 per cent between the years 1990 and 1997. However, parties' responsiveness to public shifts in support for the EU provides a mixed picture. The spread around the mean value of parties' positions on EU integration has a standard deviation of 1.36 (see Tables 1 and 2). This variation is modest when contrasted to the standard deviation of parties' positions on other issues, such as positions on welfare with 7.4, or more standard left–right positions reaching 17.58. The small variance in parties' positions on EU integration would suggest that parties chose not to differentiate between each other on this score to the same extent as on more traditional issue dimensions, and seems to indicate an opposite trend to that shown in studies of parties' positions on EU in later years where parties show relatively notable differentiation. As shown in Tables 1 and 2, political parties in countries typically characterized by limited political competition – such as Romania and Bulgaria – display systematically less differentiation than in other countries with a more developed system of

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Figure 1: Party Manifesto Scores on EU and Pro-EU Supporters in Public Compared



Source: Klingemann *et al*., 2007.

Table 1: Summary Statistics of Party Positions on EU by CEE Country 1990–97

	N	*Mean*	*Standard deviation*	*Minimum*	*Maximum*
Bulgaria	13	1.21	0.85	0.00	3.21
Czech Republic	14	1.62	1.38	0.00	3.75
Estonia	9	0.38	1.35	–2.08	2.79
Hungary	11	1.56	1.42	0.47	5.38
Latvia	4	2.20	1.97	0.00	4.76
Lithuania	16	1.05	1.50	0.00	4.17
Poland	21	1.06	1.54	–0.33	6.45
Romania	9	0.29	0.39	0.00	1.01
Slovakia	11	1.22	1.13	–0.71	2.82
Slovenia	13	0.69	1.40	–1.56	4.08

Source: Klingemann *et al*., 2007.

democratic accountability. However, relatively large differences also exist among countries with a solidly developed competitive system. In Poland, Slovenia or Estonia, for example, parties oscillate between negative scores on EU integration and positive ones, while parties in the Czech Republic or Hungary always take on positive values.

We also examine the salience of EU integration in our sample and time period. The degree to which parties choose to emphasize EU integration in their manifestos can in part help explain the mixed results that we observe with regards to parties' positional

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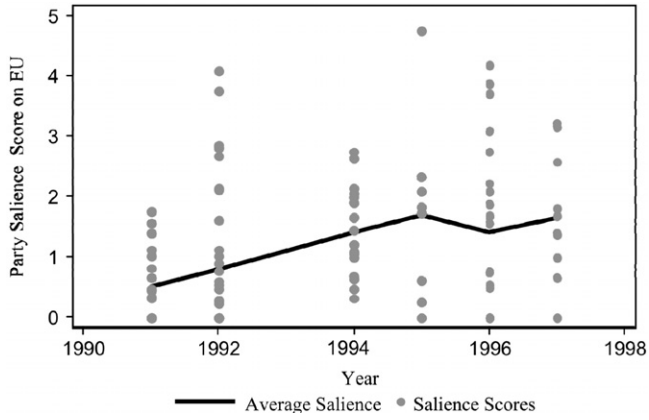
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Table 2: Summary Statistics

Variable	*N*	*Mean*	*Standard deviation*	*Minimum*	*Maximum*
Party positions on EU	121	1.09	1.36	–2.08	6.45
Distance from L–R median	108	9.51	8.10	0.13	29.37
Seat share	121	12.30	12.67	0.00	57.08
Party positions on L–R	121	6.93	17.58	–39.53	64.71
Public support for EU	120	57.15	18.94	0.00	100.00

Sources: Klingemann *et al*., 2007; Commission, 1997.

Figure 2: Average Salience of EU Integration in Party Manifestos between 1990 and 1997



Source: Klingemann *et al*., 2007.

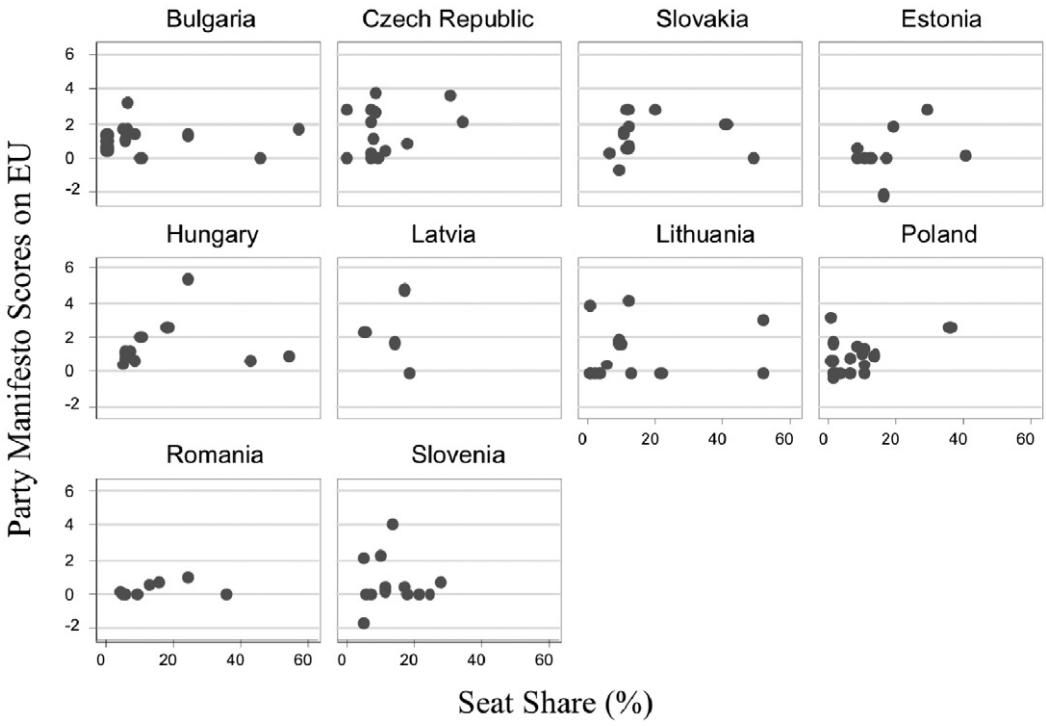
responsiveness. If EU integration issues are left out of parties' electoral agendas and emphasis is unilaterally shifted towards non-EU issues, then they may get away with not following their voter preferences on EU integration. To examine this, we calculated the absolute score on the issue of EU integration in parties' manifestos as a measure of salience by calculating the sum of absolute values of both positive and negative scores about the EU in parties' manifestos. Thus the more parties are willing to mention the EU in their political proclamations, the more salient the issue is and the higher their score. However, if the score is zero or very close to zero we conclude that parties do not consider EU integration as a salient policy issue in the particular election year.

Figure 2 plots parties' salience scores in each election year. The inspection of the results indicates that the majority of the parties do not discard the EU issue in their manifestos and, therefore, the EU has been generally a sufficiently salient issue. However, it is noteworthy that the salience of the EU issue in party manifestos increases over time. The EU is much less emphasized in countries' first elections. For example, Lithuanian parties constitute an exception in that no party in our sample devoted statements to EU integration in their first elections in 1992. An upward trend in emphasis of the EU is intuitive. Political parties in CEE emphasized EU integration more as they neared the signature of the association agreements. Political parties may have sought to increase public support around the time while mobilizing public awareness.

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Figure 3: Party Manifesto Scores on EU and Parties' Seat Share Compared



Source: Klingemann *et al*., 2007.

Finally, Figure 3 shows a comparison of parties' scores and their share of legislative seats to demonstrate the plausibility of our elite collusion hypothesis. Interestingly, parties with the highest seat share do not seem to be uniformly among the most dedicated supporters of EU integration. At first sight, no discernible pattern emerges as parties increase their likelihood of government access. Generally, all parties except for four in our sample have devoted, on balance, more positive statements to the EU than negative ones. The only exceptions are Kesk Center Party in Estonia, SNS National Party in Slovenia, Poland's UPR–Union of Real Politics and Slovakia's ZRS Workers' Association. The overwhelmingly pro-EU disposition of parties suggests a lack of real programmatic alternatives on EU integration and, therefore, that parties do not engage in full competition on this issue. Further, there does not seem to be an indication that electorally stronger parties adopted a distinctively more pro-EU position than weaker parties. Indeed, the average EU position of parties that gained over 40 per cent of parliamentary seats is about 1.03, and for parties that gained less than 40 per cent of seats it is 1.06. These numbers, however, obscure the substantial differences among individual countries and the fact that the majority of parties in multiparty systems do not typically reach 40 per cent seat share in the parliament. For example, the relationship between legislative seat share and EU scores among Czech parties reflects a nearly perfect positively linear direction. As a party's seat share increases, its pro-EU position goes up accordingly. In Slovenia, on the other hand, the relationship is less

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straightforward. After an initial increase, parties with the highest seat share devote an equal degree of positive and negative statements in their manifestos and thus have more neutral than positive disposition towards EU integration.

Table 3 summarizes the results of our four multivariate analyses. In models I and II, we simply examine our two hypotheses separately in order to observe whether any relationship exists when controlling only for country effects, serial temporal correlation and time trend. In model III, we test our two propositions in a unified model, and in model IV we run the fully specified model including additional control variables.

The findings reveal that parties' distance from the left–right median is a consistently strong predictor of parties' positions on EU integration and we find no evidence that parties, in fact, track their voters. In model II, the effect is present even without the controlling for alternative explanations of parties' position-taking on EU integration. For each party, a 10-unit movement away from the median position, the amount of positive statements devoted to EU integration in their manifestos decreases by 0.7 per cent. When viewed in light of the average percentage devoted to the EU in party manifestos, which hovers around 1 per cent, the magnitude of such a change is also substantively significant. This directional effect is robust to all specifications performed by the authors with minor variations in the overall degree and consistency of the effect. This result supports the general conclusion that more mainstream parties tend to gravitate towards pro-EU positions than parties on the more extremes of the electoral spectrum.

The effect of 'mainstreamness' is further confirmed by the effect of the party's seat share. While the effect of our seat share indicator does not meet the 95 per cent confidence standard, it reaches the 90 per cent confidence in model II and just misses 90 per cent confidence in models III and IV. Furthermore, despite the narrow miss of statistical significance, the overall effect displayed a convincing level of stability against different specifications. We suspect that the strength of the effect may be to a large extent diminished by including our two measures that explicitly tap into the same underlying theoretical concept. Thus the combined performance of our measures of party 'mainstreamness' leave us fairly comfortable about the conclusion that it is difficult to reject the claim that 'mainstreamness' promotes a pro-EU position.

Collectively, these results suggests that mainstream parties in the early period of transition democracies do not differ substantially from their counterparts in established western democracies in their propensity to adopt positions more favourable to EU integration efforts. Ultimately, one might even argue that the theoretical argument proposed above regarding anticipated EU benefits suggests that the incentive to do so on the part of parties in transition democracies should be even stronger. Our findings also run against our second hypothesis that indicates that there should be no statistically significant difference between mainstream and fringe parties when it comes to their positions on EU integration after controlling for voter preferences.

We find no evidence that parties tracked their voters on EU integration between 1990 and 1997 (Table 3). In none of our models and specifications did parties respond to changes in their likely voter's preferences on EU integration. By including the lag of the dependent variable, we effectively accounted for change in party positions rather than levels, which are less indicative of parties' reactivity to voters. This finding is striking and does seem to support the mixed picture from our earlier bivariate inspection of the data. Based on our statistical analyses, we conclude that party behaviour in the early years of

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Table 3: Party Representation on EU in Central and Eastern Europe between 1990 and 1997

	(I) Responsiveness	*(II) Collusion*	*(III) Responsiveness + Collusion*	*(IV) Responsiveness + Collusion with controls*
EU party manifesto score $_{(t-1)}$	–0.252 (0.096)	–0.145 (0.092)	–0.172* (0.091)	–0.173* (0.092)
Public support for EU (% party supporters)	0.004 (0.008)		0.013 (0.008)	0.013 (0.008)
Distance from L–R median parliamentary party		–0.070** (0.034)	–0.074** (0.033)	–0.075** (0.034)
Seat share (%)		0.02* (0.011)	0.017 (0.011)	0.017 (0.011)
L–R party manifesto score				0.001 (0.007)
Year	0.158** (0.079)	0.007 (0.085)	0.036 (0.084)	0.038 (0.086)
Czech Republic	0.799 (0.582)	–0.172 (0.535)	0.376 (0.585)	0.386 (0.592)
Estonia	–0.379 (0.66)	–1.554* (0.65)	–1.098** (0.7)	–1.101 (0.705)
Hungary	0.979 (0.611)	–0.214 (0.624)	0.113 (0.638)	0.12 (0.644)
Latvia	2.085** (0.865)	0.864 (0.87)	1.212 (0.883)	1.225 (0.893)
Lithuania	0.051 (0.518)	–0.176 (0.858)	–0.006 (0.848)	0.004 (0.856)
Poland	0.163 (0.505)	–0.349 (0.512)	–0.155 (0.512)	–0.149 (0.516)
Romania	–1.08* (0.595)	–1.952*** (0.649)	–2.055*** (0.639)	–2.040*** (0.65)
Slovakia	0.353 (0.608)	–1.167 (0.716)	–0.851 (0.733)	–0.834 (0.746)
Slovenia	–0.479 (0.566)	–1.483* (0.591)	–1.17* (0.618)	–1.157* (0.628)
Constant	0.401 (0.851)	2.274*** (0.705)	1.28 (0.928)	1.267 (0.938)
R^2	0.215	0.288	0.326	0.326
N	100	100	100	100

Sources: Klingemann *et al*., 2007; Commission, 1997.
Notes: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Bulgaria was chosen as an omitted category. Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

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Table 4: Party Representation on Free-Market Issues in Central and Eastern Europe, 1990–97

	(I) *Responsiveness*	*(II)* *Responsiveness + Controls*
Party market manifesto score $_{(t-1)}$	–0.248** (0.091)	–0.252** (0.088)
Public support for free market (% of party supporters)	0.057 (0.022)	0.047* (0.021)
L–R party manifesto score	–	0.078** (0.026)
Seat share (%)	–	–0.016 (0.034)
Distance from L–R median parliamentary party	–	0.031 (0.040)
Year	–0.527 (0.273)	–0.399 (0.267)
Czechoslovakia/Czech Republic	–3.934* (1.764)	–3.255 (1.705)
Estonia	–4.273 (2.055)	–3.345 (2.006)
Hungary	2.458 (2.171)	3.723 (2.147)
Latvia	–5.017 (2.558)	–4.324 (2.534)
Lithuania	–1.453 (2.017)	–1.461 (1.934)
Poland	–3.456 (1.790)	–3.109 (1.729)
Romania	–5.074* (2.075)	–3.933 (2.012)
Slovakia	–3.588 (2.087)	–1.991 (2.060)
Slovenia	–2.995 (1.799)	–1.823 (1.785)
Constant	6.396* (2.467)	5.155* (2.394)
R^2	0.340	0.421
N	91	91

Sources: Klingemann *et al*., 2007; Commission, 1997.
Notes: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Bulgaria was chosen as an omitted category. Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

their path to democratic transition is more in line with that suggested by the elite collusion hypothesis with little evidence for the voter–elite connection hypothesis.

Further, in the years following the signature of the accession agreements when other scholars argued or demonstrated a level of congruence between parties and voters, early transition years appear to be characterized by an insufficient level of party responsiveness. In our last model (model IV in Table 3) we sought to explore whether the lack of congruence can be accounted for by the fact that parties' positions on EU integration can be explained by their position on left–right. If left–right does explain parties' position on the EU, we have a substantial reason to suspect that EU issues fold into the left–right dimension and thus, parties did not emphasize the EU apart from the context of their positions on left–right. Similarly, we find no evidence that parties' positions on left–right account for the variation in their positions on EU integration. Therefore, this test finds no evidence that the EU position of a party is a constituent part of their left–right position.

Finally, we pit the two general findings against the propositions derived from our third argument regarding the issue of electoral volatility. As noted, observed non-responsiveness can also be explained by an alternative mechanism – that of a system-wide non-responsiveness. Thus, we compare our estimates on EU integration with parties' free-market positions to address concerns regarding the uncertainty of newly transitioning political systems. Table 4 summarizes our findings and reveals consistent evidence that the free-market position of a political party tracks constituents' preferences on the free market in line with our expectations. Thus, we find evidence that parties track voters' preferences on market issues more reliably than we observed in the case of EU integration.

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Therefore, the behaviour of political parties in the early transition years on EU integration *does* seem to systematically differ from their behaviour on free-market issues. Furthermore, our additional controls included in our analyses conform to our expectations – namely, parties' left–right position is intuitively a strong predictor of their free-market position. Thus more right-wing parties tend to adopt more favourable positions on the issue of the free market.

Finally, both indicators of 'mainstreamness' included in our theoretical argument and analyses failed to reach statistical significance. Thus, *unlike* in the context of EU integration, parties' extremeness on the ideological spectrum as well as their prominence in government seems to be *unrelated* to their position on the free market. Thus, 'extremeness' of party positions is not systematically related to their position on market issues and we find no similar theoretical reason why such an effect would be present. Yet, parties' more pronounced systematic pro-market position does not guarantee party members the benefits of governmental position any more than their less favourable position on the free market. This lack of evidence, in our view, is suggestive that the alternative theoretical mechanism in the elite collusion hypothesis is more likely to be at work.

Discussion and Conclusions

What do our findings tell us about the behaviour of political parties on issues of EU integration in transition democracies of CEE? This study complements a broader literature dealing with party responsiveness on EU integration that has been drawing increasing scholarly attention, but also further accounts for the specific characteristics of the transition democracies. In order to develop a comprehensive understanding of the manner in which parties position themselves on increasingly more relevant issues of EU integration, current theoretical frameworks demand corresponding empirical scrutiny drawing from both western and eastern Europe.

Our conclusions are threefold. In contrast to later studies that examine party positions on the EU from the early 2000s onward, we can find no evidence that parties respond to their respective constituencies on the EU issues prior to 1997. The lack of responsiveness, however, cannot be explained in the majority of cases by deliberate de-emphasis of the EU in parties' electoral campaigns by incorporating the EU into their left–right positions. Further, such absence of party–voter position correspondence cannot be explained by the instability of public and party positions on policy issues in general during this time period. Our comparison of parties' behaviour on EU integration with their responses on market issues showed consistent evidence that EU integration indeed stands apart as parties seem much less willing to track their voters than in the case of free-market issues.

While we do not find large variation in parties' positions on EU integration, we find that there is systematic evidence that mainstream parties favour EU integration more than fringe parties. These findings conform to arguments that suggest a degree of collusion among the main parties and that EU integration is ultimately an elite-driven project. In this sense, CEE countries in the early years seem to be no different.

We consciously framed this article in terms of the debates regarding how prospects of membership in the EU can influence the level of party representation in transition democracies. While the effect of supranational actors is often argued to strengthen democratic capacity of countries in transition, the incentives created by prospective membership may

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also trump representative concerns on certain issues in these countries for a temporary period. We are cautious, however, in inferring from our analyses causal evidence that anticipated benefits were, in fact, the concrete mechanism that drove party positions on EU integration. Yet, we present a plausible argument supported by tentative empirical evidence that can be further directly tested by future studies. Our hopes are that the analyses presented in this article provide a useful starting point and contribution for future theoretical and empirical exploration of the impact of the EU on representation in countries in democratic transition.

Correspondence:
Lucie Spanihelova
Lange Voorhout 86
2514 EJ The Hague
The Netherlands
email: l.spanihelova@montesquieu-instituut.nl

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